

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



An unfinished electric school bus sits in the shuttered Lion Electric factory on May 24 in Joliet. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

Funding freeze disrupts research

Worried Northwestern lab directors describe 'bleak' atmosphere

By Zareen Syed
Chicago Tribune

The Trump administration's freezing in April of \$790 million in federal research funding for Northwestern University has left concerned lab directors without key grant money from the National Institutes of Health and forced the university to spend millions to keep vital research afloat and to continue to pay graduate workers and scientists.

Carole LaBonne, a professor of molecular biosciences at Northwestern, said the situation at the prominent research institution can only be described as "bleak" as the halt in federal funds continues to send shockwaves across the Evanston campus.

"You're at risk of losing an entire next generation of scientists, and these are the researchers who are going to be driving tomorrow's discoveries and cures," LaBonne told the Tribune. "It has short-term impacts, it has long-term impacts — it's terrifying; it's completely senseless."

Northwestern officials did not confirm how much the university is spending to keep research going there, but LaBonne said that is widely known among the science faculty, who were recently notified by the dean of the Weinberg College of Arts and Sciences in a meeting that it is costing Northwestern more than \$10 million a week.

"The university is working very hard to advocate on behalf of research and our researchers," a Northwestern spokesperson said in a statement. "Our lifesaving research improves our society and has a multibillion-dollar impact on our economy."

In recent letters to the campus community, Northwestern President Michael Schill and other administrators said the university has received about 100 stop-work orders, mostly Department of Defense-funded research projects, and about 50 grant terminations.

In addition, officials said Northwestern researchers have not received payments for National Institutes of Health grants since March, signaling that those funds have been frozen, despite no official word from the Trump

Turn to University, Page 4

What went wrong at Lion Electric?

Democrats, Canada and Lion itself all played a role in the vehicle maker's failure

By John Lippert | Chicago Tribune

The windshields still haunted Tom Olson as he walked through the Lion Electric school bus factory in Joliet for the final time last month.

During nearly three years as the factory's manufacturing engineer, he'd never been able to get the windshield to fit properly onto the fiberglass shell that covers the bus's metal frame. The company's top brass, swimming against a tide of red ink back home in Quebec, never fixed the design.

Starting with the very first bus, he said, workers had to anchor the sides of the windshields with extra-thick helpings of a sticky gray sealant that they called goop.

"The sealant will be fine for the first year. But what really scares me is, what's it going to do after three or four Midwest winters?" Olson said. "I don't think they'll lose a window. But I know it's going to leak."

Olson worked at Lion Electric until Thanksgiving. On the Sunday after the holiday, he received an email saying the factory had closed.

His return to the place where, at age 60, he'd been hoping to finish his career came during a liquidation sale. He said his silent goodbyes amid a steady stream of industrial scavengers from around the Midwest. And he kept replaying in his head all the mistakes, all the missed opportunities.



Tom Olson, who worked as a manufacturing engineer at the Lion Electric school bus factory in Joliet, looks at an electric motor left on a school bus chassis at the shuttered factory.

Figuring out what went wrong at Lion Electric is crucial not just for former employees, but also for politicians, corporate leaders and environmentalists who want Illinois to build more battery-powered vehicles and protect future generations from increasingly toxic air.

Gov. JB Pritzker has touted Illinois as a clean energy leader since the 2021 passage of his Climate and Equitable Jobs Act, which will ban the burning of coal and gas to make electricity by 2045.

Turn to Lion, Page 2

Cook Co. property tax reforms fail to materialize in Springfield

As homeowners see bills rise, relief measures stall out; county officials to try again this year

By A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Legislative reforms to Cook County's property tax system almost uniformly stalled this legislative session, halting efforts to give tax breaks to more seniors and those walloped with big bills, and to help people hang on to some of their homes' value if they lose the properties because of unpaid taxes.

When tax bills will ultimately hit mailboxes, meanwhile, is still in flux, as tech upgrades continue at the county's property tax offices. Those bills will have fresh numbers that reflect Chicago's latest reassessment.

With most countywide officeholders facing reelection next year, many are looking to address long-standing

complaints about rising property tax bills so they can tell voters they're working on it.

Assessor Fritz Kaegi estimates about 237,000 people in Cook County saw their bills go up by at least 25% during the last property tax cycle, sparking concerns about homeowners' ability to keep up with their bills and, ultimately, stay in their homes.

County officials said this spring's budget and transit debates overshadowed property tax ones and hope to make more progress in Springfield later this year.

An overhaul of the county's tax sale process spearheaded by Treasurer Maria Pappas was among the more prominent reforms to sputter out. Pappas' legislation would have

changed the way the county handles delinquent taxes to ensure those who don't catch up on their property tax bills can still pocket some of their home's value if it's turned over to a private investor.

The reforms would have swapped out the county's current way of dealing with the sale of past-due taxes. Private investors — known as tax buyers — can currently win a deed to a home outright if a homeowner doesn't pay up in a certain amount of time.

In 2023, the Supreme Court found the government of Hennepin County, Minnesota, was unfairly pocketing proceeds from homes and businesses sold after years of property tax delinquency. The ruling spurred several states with similar foreclosure processes to change their systems and

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INSIDE



ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago ICE protest joins others nationwide

A rally in the Lower West Side neighborhood decried aggressive raids and police cooperation. Meanwhile, President Donald Trump sent the National Guard to Los Angeles as protesters continued to rally there. **Nation & World**

New details in officer's mistaken fatal shooting

Moments before she was mistakenly shot by her partner, CPD Officer Krystal Rivera was pursuing a person who now faces charges. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 72 Low 56

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 14

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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